

WADA Dabba Doo

The objections by Indian cricketers to a 'whereabouts' clause in an anti-doping code hold no ground: not on privacy, security or even personal inconvenience

| By Sharda Ugra |

What's your take on airport security checks? Taking off your shoes, belt, jacket, in a queue with the other shoeless, beltless, jacketless walking around in socks or barefoot? Getting frisked? Having strangers open up your bags and go through your stuff? Feels like an invasion of privacy sometimes, doesn't it? Well, that's just too bad; if you need to fly between countries, those are the rules to live by.

What the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) is asking of Indian cricketers is something similar.

The 'whereabouts' clause under which cricketers must guarantee their presence for an hour every day over three months is an inconvenience, a nuisance and an invasion of privacy. But it is a rule with a reason. More than 20,000 athletes have moaned and grumbled and complained, but have all signed up to this rule. So what exactly makes the 11 dissenting Indian cricketers (nine men and two women) exempt is hard to see.

Their primary concern, privacy and an infringement on free time, applies to every other high-profile athlete too. To assuage the cricketers' outrage, the ICC has, however, said that it is unlikely that the testing would take place during a player's holiday time. The WADA, however, must have the option of testing at all times, regardless of whether that option is exercised. Because not everyone on their list plays all three forms of cricket. Players could be recovering from injury, away from team camps or travelling.

The argument that security will be compromised is actually laughable, even though a few Indians have received terrorist threats. Well, the Anti-Doping Administration & Management System (ADAMS) is built to be leakproof (more leak proof than the BCCI anyway) with online security systems protocols similar to those used in international banking.

The information uploaded on ADAMS will be accessible to only two people in the ICC who it is pretty sure will not dash off faxes to the Lashkar. An athlete can even authorise another individual to update his informa-

tion, a job easily handed over to managers, updates requiring only a phone call. All this sufficiently covers concerns about privacy, security and even personal hassles.

Ideally, the BCCI should have sounded out its players well before the July 31 deadline to explain how the system was going to work, asked them to give it try-out for four months and register their complaints in time for the WADA review due in December. Cricketers from other countries have signed up despite reservations, (why the ultra-argumentative FICA chose not to raise the issue is a mystery). There is a middle ground on this issue and basketball for example appears to have found it: the NBA is not a signatory to the WADA though its professionals are a part of the Olympics.

So the argument that Indian players are crushing cricket's Olympian ambition is a bit thin. A sizeable section of the ICC does fancy the idea of cricket going to the Games. The BCCI remains decidedly frosty. It's got nothing to do with the lack of five-star accommodation at the Olympics. (And those ceremonies? Man, do they last forever). Here, curiously enough, India has support from its otherwise habitual adversary, England, who find that most Olympics clash with their cricket season. If England were to send a full-strength squad to an Olympic Games, it would affect its broadcasting contracts. The BCCI, of course, is not interested in sending *their* full-strength squad anywhere for two weeks without any inputs into the coffers. That said, no one is fling-

ing Mont Blancs or mobiles across tables over the issue just yet: cricket's participation at the Olympics is not yet a pressing concern. It will be four years before the sports for the 2020 Olympics are decided.

Should cricket be at the Olympics? Frankly, no. The Olympics should feature only those disciplines for which an Olympic gold is the highest achievement, not dilettantes stopping by for some hoopla.

But should cricketers be tested regularly and out of competition for banned substances like other athletes? Most definitely. ■

More than 20,000 athletes have signed up to WADA. What makes 11 cricketers exempt is hard to see.

